

SDSC Established 1971

From successfully launching India's first moon mission to renting rockets to other countries to launch their satellites, the Satish Dhawan Space Centre is not just the ISRO hub, but also the pride of India's space missions

PLANET VISION



G. Madhavan Nair 66, Chairman, ISRO

"We have begun to cash in on our space launcher capabilities and there are opportunities to grow with the pressures of global competition."

October 1971, it is from here that the country shot into space.

What was known as the Sriharikota Range (SHAR), became SDSC SHAR in 2002 in the memory of the former chairman of Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). The choice of Sriharikota, made way back in 1969, as the country's Cape Canaveral, is because of its location and logistical advantages—a good launch position that comes from a location that takes advantage of the earth's rotation for eastward launchings, its closeness to the equator where the linear velocity of the earth's surface is greatest, and the nearby expanse of the Bay of Bengal as a safety zone.

By successfully injecting multiple satellites in a single launch, ISRO and SDSC have managed to carve a niche in the global space market, offering cost-effective satellite lift-offs to overseas customers. Canada, Japan, The Netherlands and Israel are turning to India and its rent-a-rocket business to launch their satellites. The Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle has repeatedly proved its reliability and versatility by launching 30 satellites/spacecraft—14 Indian and 16 for overseas customers—to demonstrate its multi-satellite launch capability.

With infrastructure for launching satellites into low earth orbit, polar and geostationary transfer orbit, what SDSC can now do is to lob the easier-to-launch and cost-effective small research satellites for ocean studies, atmospheric physics and remote sensing. The big business is in the larger communication satellites, which ISRO has the requisite expertise to make, but SDSC is still to develop the strengths to launch.

Given the ambitious drive of ISRO and the curbs on ferrying satellites with US components on its launchers being lifted, the SDSC is poised to arrive soon in the big league of launch behemoths like the European Space Agency and NASA.

by Amarnath K. Menon

The crowning triumph of India's ambitious space mission came in 2008 with the launch of the first lunar orbiter Chandrayaan-1 from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre (SDSC) in Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh. But what is more gratifying about SDSC is that it

will be the main base for India's manned mission to the moon by 2015. With two operational orbital launch pads, the second in use only since 2005, Sriharikota is India's celebrated spaceport. Beginning with the launch of a simple sounding rocket, RH-125, in

Rs 386 crore
was India's budgetary estimate for realising its first-ever lunar mission Chandrayaan-1.

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